

ABSOLUTE MONARCHY



In an absolute monarchy, power is held by the ruling monarch of the country and is handed down through the royal family to his or her successor. In the past, absolute monarchs kept all power to themselves, but today most appoint a small advisory council to help them rule.

MONARCHY WITH A PARTIAL DEMOCRATIC SYSTEM

In some countries, the ruling monarch retains a strong grip on the government but allows some limited democracy. In Jordan, King Abdullah allows direct elections to the lower House of Representatives, but keeps strong control by appointing all 55 members of the upper house, or Senate.



DICTATORSHIP



A number of countries around the world are ruled by single rulers, called dictators, who have absolute authority. Most dictators gain power either through military coups (an army takeover), by seizing leadership from an existing ruler, as in Iraq, or through direct elections and then banning opposition parties. Once in office, dictators rule in a personal, often brutal, fashion, eliminating all opposition to themselves.

Dictator of the Central African Republic from 1965 to 1975, Jean-Bédél Boukassa crowned himself "emperor" in 1977.

MILITARY GOVERNMENT

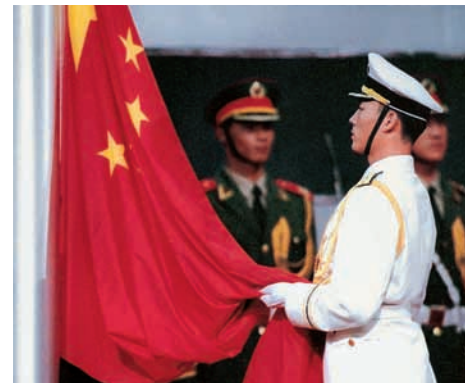


Military governments are usually set up after the army has seized

leadership from a weak or unpopular government. An example of a military government is Pakistan, where the military under Pervez Musharraf seized power. All power is held by senior military officers, usually drawn from the army. Elections and parliament are abolished and political parties are declared illegal. Military governments have often held power in South and Central America, Africa, and Asia.

EMPIRE

Empire is when one country controls a number of other countries, usually under the control of one ruler or emperor. Empires have existed since ancient times, though the 18th and 19th centuries are often called "the Age of Empire," since this was when the European powers expanded their rule throughout the continents of South America, Africa, and Asia. Today, only small pockets of these European empires remain.



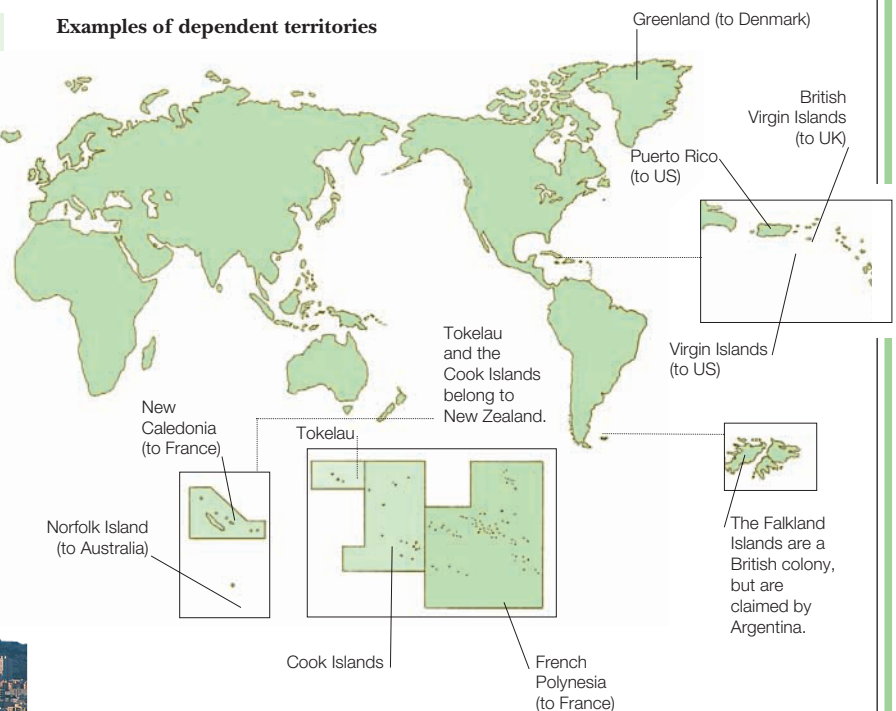
Hong Kong was handed back to the Chinese after 157 years of British rule in 1997.

DEPENDENT TERRITORIES

Not every country rules itself. About 10 million people around the world live under the protection of either the UK, Denmark, Norway, France, the Netherlands, the US, New Zealand, or Australia. Most dependent territories are relics of the colonial era that have remained attached to their former colonial rulers. Some territories have recently changed status. Hong Kong, for example, reverted from British to Chinese rule in 1997. Some territories are retained because of their strategic or economic importance, while others remain colonies because they are too small, remote, or weak to survive on their own.



Examples of dependent territories



Gibraltar is a self-governing British colony, captured from the Spanish in 1704.